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Culture (OWC): [Gusii \(FL08\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: No Date

Coverage Date: 1955-1957

Place Coverage

Community of Nyansongo (a pseudonym), Southwestern Kenya, East Africa

Section Title(S): Methods Of Combating Witchcraft

The *omoriori* or witch-smeller is a hired specialist who removes the effects of witchcraft rather than retaliating against witches.¹ A person who believes himself bewitched may either summon a witch-smeller immediately or resort to one after a sorcerer has failed to produce the desired results. Unlike the sorcerer the witch-smeller always practises in public; no attempt is made to conceal the fact that one has summoned him. The people of Nyansongo called upon numerous sorcerers, mostly from western Gusiiland (near the Luo country), but there was only one witch-smeller known to them, Mochama Mororamba, a clansman of theirs who lives only a few miles away. Independent investigation revealed that Mochama is reputed to be the outstanding practitioner of his art; he practises, with the permission of their respective chiefs, in most of the administrative locations of Gusiiland as well as on the European plantations of Kericho District. Some elders of the African Tribunal Court said they considered him a mercenary faker, but he appeared to have gained a social prestige and legitimacy unparalleled among contemporary supernatural specialists in Gusiiland. All of the information presented here concerning the *omoriori* and his art (*okoriora*) is based on interviews with Mochama and observation of him at work.

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Mochama claims to have learned his craft from his father who in turn learned it from his father. He wears the uniform of a tribal policeman with the words 'South Nyanza' sewn on to it and tells people that he is licensed and employed by the Government to eliminate witchcraft. He carries letters from chiefs and police officials and shows them to his (mostly illiterate) clients to prove his official status. Despite this attempt to identify himself with governmental authority, Mochama is not a frightening figure like a sorcerer. With one obviously blind eye (about which he jokes), a high-pitched voice, and a good-humoured manner, he is regarded as a somewhat comical and friendly fellow. People nevertheless respect him and his talents and enable [238](#) him to drive a hard bargain. He demands cash, cows, and goats in payment, always in excess of what his clients are willing (or claim they are able) to pay; he often rejects the first cow proffered and selects a better one from the client's herd.

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Sometimes he stops his performance and demands more money before he will go on.

¹ For a more graphic and detailed presentation of the *omoriori* (with twelve photographs), see LeVine (1958).

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